

7.2 The opportunities and challenges of urbanisation

This chapter will explain:

- ★ the opportunities of urban living
- ★ the challenges of urban living
- ★ the impacts of urban sprawl on the rural-to-urban fringe.

The opportunities of urban living

In 2018, 55 per cent of the world's population lived in urban areas. By 2050, this could reach 68 per cent. This is because urban areas offer many opportunities, as they attract many people to live there. For example, many large urban areas offer numerous cultural facilities such as museums, art galleries, sporting venues, historic buildings and places of worship. There are also more cultures and ethnicities represented in urban areas. Diversity and inclusiveness are more likely in an urban area due to the varied backgrounds of its residents.

Many urban areas provide a greater number of well-built homes, and different types of homes including houses, flats and apartments. The range of services is greater in urban areas, including educational, healthcare, retail, as well as leisure and entertainment facilities such as cinemas, theatres, restaurants and clubs. Many of these are very accessible to urban residents due to the public transport that is available. Many cities are walkable – the so called '15-minute' cities, with high population densities and good access to services, facilities and employment.

For many, it is the number and range of jobs that are available in urban areas that is the biggest attraction. Most migrants move to large urban areas because they believe they can earn more than in a rural area or small urban area. Urban areas are centres of business, commerce and industry, and up to 80 per cent of global GDP is generated by cities.



▲ **Figure 7.6** Multiculturalism is a characteristic of large urban areas

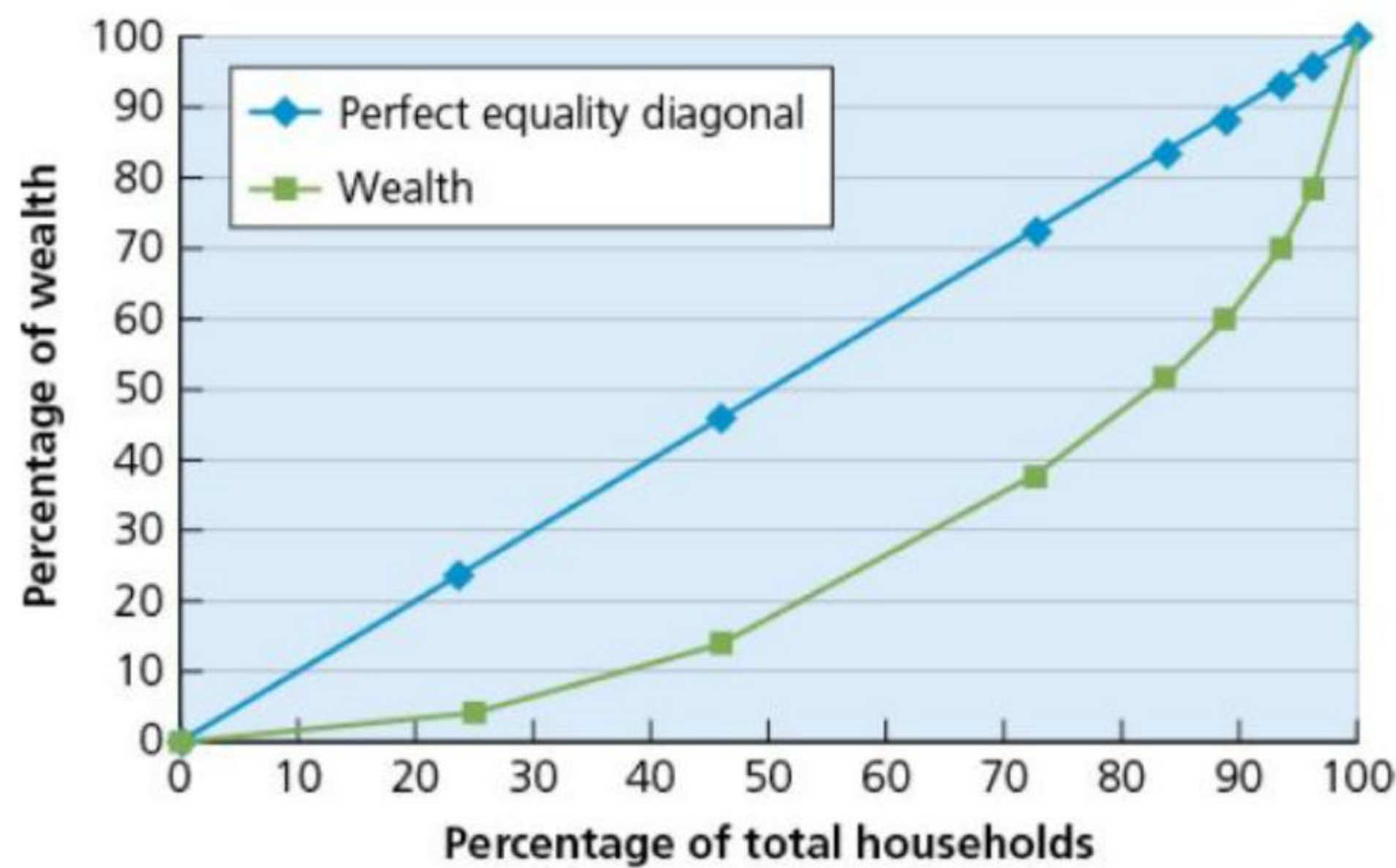
For example, in New York City, the 'Big Apple', there are many financial jobs associated with Wall Street, political/administrative jobs associated with the United Nations, jobs in entertainment associated with Broadway and Times Square, and many others. It also has some of the world's top universities such as Columbia University, New York University and Pace University. New York has an advanced public transport system. The subway system has over 1000 km of track, the Metropolitan Transportation Authority runs a fleet of over 6000 buses, and there is a very popular ferry system, the Staten Island Ferry. In terms of entertainment, many residents and tourists are attracted by what is on offer on Broadway, Times Square, Chinatown and Little Italy. New York also offers much open space, such as Central Park, Prospect Park and Coney Island. It is also associated with sports such as baseball and tennis. The New York Yankees are internationally known and the US Tennis Open is held at Flushing Meadow in the Bronx.

The challenges of urban living

On the other hand, there are challenges associated with urban living.

Inequality

Inequalities in income are a feature of many urban areas ([Figure 7.7](#)). Urban areas contain many wealthy residents, such as people working in financial services, lawyers, doctors and businesspeople, and also low-paid workers such as cleaners, caterers and informal workers, as well as those who are out of work. This leads to large income inequalities.



▲ **Figure 7.7** Income inequality in Rio de Janeiro, shown on a Lorenz curve

Service provision

Service provision in urban areas is highly variable. For example, Woodstock is an inner suburb of Cape Town, South Africa, whereas Blikkiesdorp is a relocation camp made up of about 1600 one-roomed tin structures ([Figure 7.8](#)). Woodstock experienced urban renewal and gentrification (the movement into the area of young professional workers) in the 1970s and 1980s, and this led to the growth of service provision such as fashionable restaurants, ICT and other businesses and offices ([Figure 7.9](#)), whereas Blikkiesdorp is a lower-income area and has not attracted much service provision ([Figure 7.10](#)).

Housing

There is a lack of sufficient quality housing in all countries. There are at least four aspects to the management of housing stock:

- » Quality of housing – with adequate water, sanitation and space



▲ **Figure 7.8** The location of Woodstock and Blikkiesdorp, Cape Town



▲ **Figure 7.9** Services in Woodstock, Cape Town



▲ **Figure 7.10** Housing in Blikkiesdorp, Cape Town

- » Quantity of housing – having enough housing to meet demand
- » Availability and affordability of housing
- » Housing tenure (e.g. ownership or rental).

Increased demand for housing is caused by:

- » people moving to urban areas in search of work and a higher standard of living
- » longer life expectancy
- » young people leaving home earlier
- » more families breaking up and moving into separate homes
- » more people preferring modern housing with good facilities.

The cost of housing and living is higher in urban areas than in rural areas. Urban areas may be overcrowded, and people may feel more stress and pressure in their daily lives, for example commuting to work. Air quality can be low due to emissions from factories, vehicles and public transport networks. There is also much less open space in urban areas compared with rural areas. Transport can be very congested, leading to longer travel times to get to places such as hospitals.

High competition for space and resources leads to smaller houses and gardens in large urban areas. There is a shortage of affordable housing in many cities. In some LICs, parts of the urban population make their own homes (informal housing). Up to 1 billion people live in informal settlements, which may be very overcrowded ([Figure 7.11](#)) and lacking in basic facilities, such as sanitation, clean water and electricity. Up to 50 per cent of displaced people live in urban areas, placing stress on these areas to provide for all their residents.

Employment

Employment is another challenge in urban areas. This may occur because the number of people seeking work exceeds the number of jobs that are available. There are a number of options available:

- » The government can create more jobs through public works programmes, for example building infrastructure that benefits the urban area.
- » People can find jobs themselves in the informal economy.
- » People can job-share.
- » People may work part-time.



▲ **Figure 7.11** High-density housing, Petionville, Port-au-Prince, Haiti – the brightly coloured homes on the left of the photo were painted as part of a government project to improve impoverished areas

Transport

Transport problems in urban areas include congestion and poor air quality. Congestion can delay journeys and make people late for school, work or appointments. It increases fuel consumption and adds to vehicular emissions of greenhouse gases and other pollutants. It may lead to frustration and ‘road rage’ and it can have a negative impact on people’s health through stress and poor air quality. In 2013 the World Health Organization announced that air pollution can cause cancer. Diesel fumes are carcinogenic, and air pollution has a causal link with respiratory diseases.

Waste management

Waste management is a major issue for large urban areas. For example, London produces about 7 million tonnes of rubbish per year from homes, public buildings and businesses. Some of this is disposed of in landfill sites, some is burned to generate electricity, and some is recycled. On average most households produce around 1000 kg of waste yearly.

About half of London’s waste is recycled and most of the rest goes to landfill, but many landfill sites are likely to be full by 2026. London plans to recycle 65 per cent of its waste by 2030. The city produces 1.5 to 1.75 million tonnes of food waste annually, valued at about £2.5 billion. Much of this waste goes to landfill but some is incinerated to create energy from waste.

Unplanned settlements

Unplanned settlements in LICs may be bulldozed without warning. However, since authorities are unable to offer alternative housing, they often leave the unplanned settlements alone. Some say that these unplanned settlements are the solution to the housing shortage in LICs, as less wealthy people have built their homes and do not require housing to be supplied by the government.

Activities

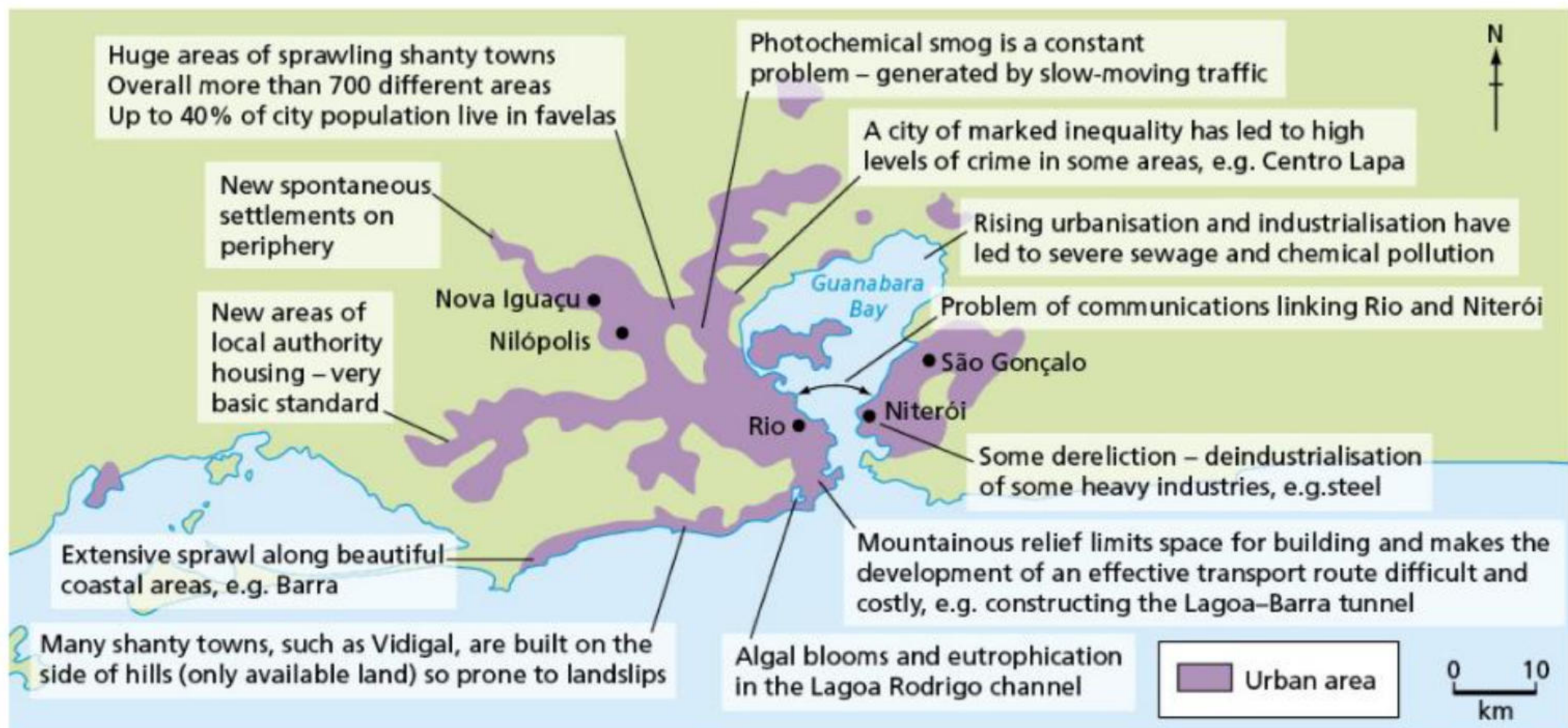
- 1 Outline the opportunities of living in urban environments.
 - 2 Identify the problems of waste management in urban environments.
 - 3 Suggest reasons why housing can be an issue in urban areas.
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Favela Barrio Project

The Favela Barrio Project (Favela Neighbourhood Project) began in Rio de Janeiro in 1994. It aimed to recognise favelas (informal settlements) as neighbourhoods of the city in their own right and to provide the residents with essential services ([Figure 7.12](#)). Around 120 medium-sized favelas (those with 500–2500 households) were chosen to be part of the project.

The first phase of the project addressed the built environment, aiming to provide:

- » paved and formally named roads
- » water supply pipes and sewerage/drainage systems
- » crèches, leisure facilities and sports areas
- » relocation for families who were then living in high-risk areas, such as areas subject to frequent landslides
- » channelled rivers to stop them from changing course.



▲ **Figure 7.12** Informal housing in Rio de Janeiro

The second phase of the project aimed to bring the favela dwellers into mainstream society and keep them away from crime. This is being done by:

- » generating employment, for example by creating cooperatives of dressmakers, cleaners and construction workers, and helping them to establish themselves in the labour market
- » improving education and providing relevant courses, such as ICT
- » giving residents access to credit so they can buy construction materials and improve their homes.

The project has been used as a model of its type. The government is also helping people to become homeowners.

A number of developments have taken place to try to improve the quality of the education system. *Amigos da Escola* (school friends) encourages people from the community to volunteer their skills to improve opportunities offered by their local schools. *Bolsa Escola* (school grants) gives monthly financial incentives to low-income families to keep their children at school.

Rocinha is a central favela with a population of about 200,000 inhabitants ([Figure 7.13](#)). Over 90 per cent of the buildings are now constructed from brick and have electricity, running water and sewerage systems. Rocinha has its own newspapers and radio station. There are food and clothes shops, video rental shops, bars, a travel agent and, at one stage, a McDonald's fast-food outlet. Nearly all of this was achieved by the local community and their initiatives, often without government support. However, the lack of security of tenure means that many companies and/or political organisations do not invest in informal settlements as any improvements could be discarded.



▲ **Figure 7.13** Rocinha, Rio de Janeiro

Many of these improvements and developments are the result of Rocinha's location, close to wealthy areas

such as São Conrado and Copacabana. Many of the residents work in these wealthy areas surrounding Rocinha and, although monthly incomes are low, they are not as low as elsewhere in the city and in Brazil as a whole. These regular incomes have allowed improvements to be carried out by the residents themselves. A distinction has been made between settlements known as ‘slums of hope’ (the more central informal settlements, such as Rocinha, that are closer to the city centre and where access to employment is therefore better), and those known as ‘slums of despair’ (the informal settlements on the outskirts of the city, such as Caxias, where access to employment is more limited).

Ways in which people can adapt to living in urban areas (if they have the choice and resources to do so) include:

- » by living near public transport routes
- » by shopping locally
- » by utilising public spaces like parks and facilities such as libraries
- » by creating communities.

Activities

- 1 Identify three measures or pieces of evidence of inequality within Rio de Janeiro.
- 2 Suggest why there is a housing shortage in Rio de Janeiro.
- 3 Outline the opportunities of living in squatter settlements.
- 4 Distinguish between settlements that are called ‘slums of hope’ and those that are called ‘slums of despair’.

The impacts of urban sprawl on the rural-to-urban fringe/surrounding areas

Urban sprawl is uncontrolled, outward growth at the edges of urban areas. Positive aspects include greater land availability and cheaper land, so that companies can expand and larger houses with bigger gardens can be built. However, negative impacts include the erosion of agricultural land, less food production, increased commuting, a decline in air quality, degradation of local ecosystems, a decline in local biodiversity and a reduction of ecosystem services such as climate regulation and flood control ([Table 7.1](#)). It also leads to land-use conflicts as many different groups compete for the land.

▼ **Table 7.1** Issues in the urban fringe

Land use	Positive aspects	Negative aspects
Agriculture	Some farms may diversify into alternative activities, such as ‘pick your own food’	- Farms on the urban fringe often suffer litter, trespass and vandalism - Some land is left derelict in the hope that planning permission for development will be granted
New developments	Some developments are well-sited and landscaped, such as business and science parks	- Some developments, such as out-of-town shopping areas, may cause traffic congestion and pollution - Many businesses are unregulated, for example scrap metal processing/storage
Urban services	Some can be seen as attractive compared with dense built-up areas, e.g. cemeteries have lots of open space and flowers, and reservoirs may have many water birds	Sewage works, markets, car boot sales and landfill sites can be unattractive and polluting
Transport infrastructure	Cycleways can improve access and promote new development	Motorways destroy countryside, especially near junctions
Recreation and sport	Country parks, sports fields and golf courses can include conservation	Car racing and scrambling/climbing erode ecosystems and create localised litter and pollution
Landscape and nature conservation	Conservation areas may be included at the edge of the city	There may be degraded land, for example land affected by dumping or ‘fly-tipping’

Recent developments in the rural-to-urban fringe include the construction of roads, especially peripheral ring roads, housing developments, out-of-town shopping centres ([Figure 7.14](#)), science parks and industrial estates.



▲ **Figure 7.14** An out-of-town supermarket, with free parking and good accessibility for workers and customers

Many businesses **decentralise** to the rural-to-urban fringe because of good levels of accessibility for road transport, space to offer free parking and a clean, attractive environment. According to the World Bank, between 2016 and 2030 the physical growth of urban areas is likely to be about 1.2 million km².

Many transport schemes, such as much of the M25 in the UK, are located in the rural-to-urban fringe. Park-and-ride schemes (in which commuters park their car in a car park and then take a bus to the city) are located in the urban fringe. Housing developments also take advantage of greenfield sites (previously undeveloped sites) in the rural-to-urban fringe, but they contribute to urban sprawl.

Urban sprawl has become a feature of many cities in the USA. Some geographers predict that the whole area between Phoenix and Tucson in Arizona could become one enormous urban sprawl by 2100. Phoenix is 70 per cent larger in area than New York City, but has only 20 per cent of the population of New York City ([Figure 7.15](#)). Phoenix has been described as the 'world's least sustainable city', although many of its suburbs on the rural-to-urban fringe, such as Anthem, a planned community, are extremely popular as places to live.

The car industry and the oil industry have enabled settlements to spread out along super-corridors and highways. One downside has been the enhanced stress on society, with increases in road rage and congestion and declining air quality.

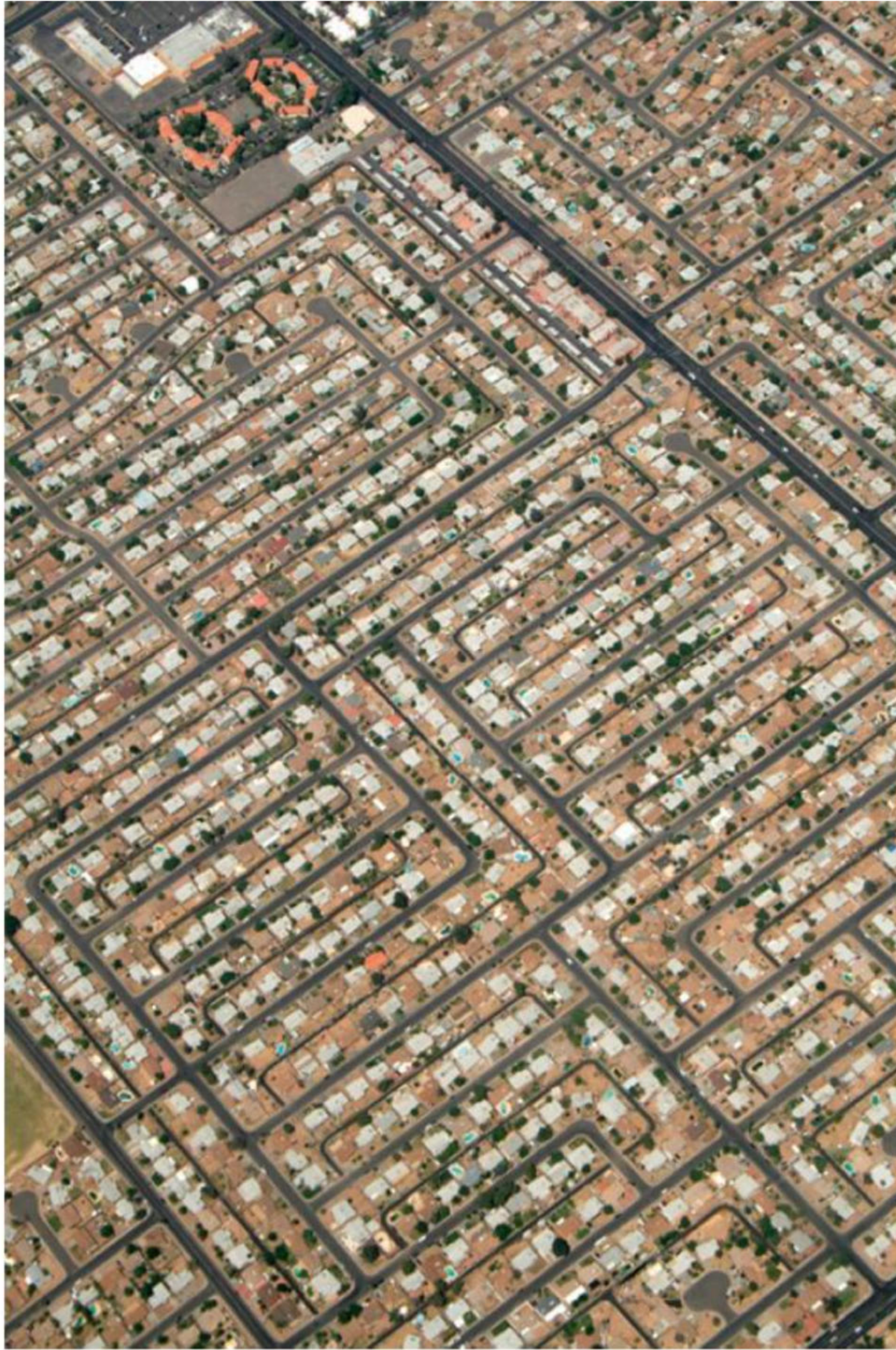
Some countries have introduced green belts (also known as green wedges, greenways or green spaces) to restrict urban sprawl and protect the natural and semi-natural environment. These areas improve air quality, reduce the risk of flooding and enable people (with cars) to access the countryside.

Interesting note

The first green belt was established by the Prophet Muhammad PBUH in the seventh century, around Medina in what is now Saudi Arabia.

Activities

- 1 Explain reasons for the growth of developments in the rural-to-urban fringe.
 - 2 Suggest how developments in the rural-to-urban fringe impact the natural environment.
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▲ **Figure 7.15** Residential urban sprawl west of Phoenix, Arizona